

EXCERPT FROM HIS NEXT BOOK

None of the other shopkeepers near the railway station would hire a Muslim, but Ramanna Shetty, who ran the Ideal Store, a tea-and-samosa place, told Ziauddin it was okay for him to stay.

Provided he promised to work hard. And keep away from all hanky-panky.

The little, dust-covered creature let its bag drop to the ground; a hand went up to its heart.

'I'm a Muslim, sir. We don't do hanky-panky.'

Ziauddin was small and black, with baby fat in his cheeks, and an elfin grin that exposed big, white, rabbit teeth. He boiled tea for the customers in an enormous, pitted stainless-steel kettle, watching with furious concentration as the water seethed, overspilled, and sizzled into the gas flame. Periodically, he dug his palm into one of the battered stainless steel boxes by his side to

toss black tea powder, or a handful of white sugar, or a piece of crushed ginger into the brew. He sucked his lips in, held his breath, and tipped the kettle with his left forearm into a strainer: hot tea dripped through the clogged pores of the strainer into small, tapering glasses sitting in the slots of a paper carton originally designed to hold eggs.

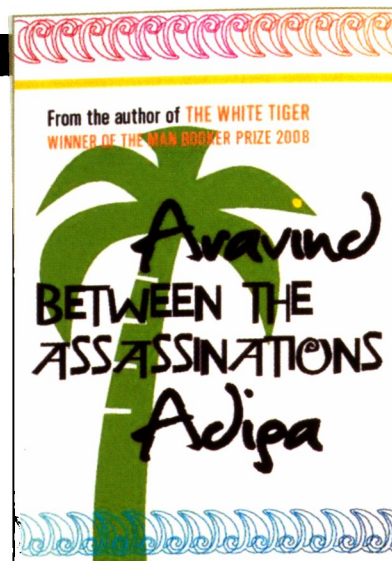
Taking the glasses one at a time to the tables, he delighted the rough men who came to the teashop by interrupting their conversation with shouts of 'One-a! Two-a! Three-a—!' while slamming the glasses down in front of them. Later, the men would see him squatting by the side of the shop, soaking the dishes in a large trough filled with murky bilge water; or wrapping greasy samosas in pages ripped from college trigonometry textbooks so they could be home-delivered; or scooping the gunk of tea leaves out of the filter; or tightening, with a rusty screwdriver, a loose screw on

India of Darkness."

It is not the sociology of his narrative alone that makes Adiga, 33, one of the most distinctive voices in fiction today, even though the sociology is steeped in anger and wit, satire and scatology. He is a writer who, like some of the best at work today, is in permanent argument with the world he has inherited. It is a world he first came to contact with as a journalist. And then he realised it was a world that could not be captured in its entirety, in all its moral and political ambiguities, in a reporter's notebook. In more socially motivated but less subtle hands, *The*

White Tiger would have lost its soul. It is a novel whose architectural cleverness is matched by its inherent humanism. Adiga never misses the stirrings of denial and dispossession beneath the sheen of India Shining. As his protagonist says, the rooster coop is "the greatest thing to come out of this country in the ten thousand years of its history." It is all about entrapment and submission, and Adiga—born in Chennai, educated at Oxford and Columbia—doesn't fancy himself as the redeemer of the entrapped: "I'm no social activist" (see *interview*).

His imagination, though, has



SUBLIME TALE: The cover of Adiga's next book

the back of a chair. Whenever a word was said in English all work stopped: the boy would turn around and repeat the word at the top of his voice ('Sunday-Monday, Goodbye, Sexy!'), and the entire shop shook with laughter. (from *Between the Assassinations*, published by Picador India)

brought out vintage Booker spirit. The Booker that was won by Adiga was the same prize that once reached out to writers like V.S. Naipaul, Salman Rushdie, J.M. Coetzee, Michael Ondaatje, Kazuo Ishiguro, Ben Okri, Arundhati Roy and Kiran Desai. For the Booker, at its best, celebrated the boldest and the most original from the erstwhile colonies of the Empire. It was partial to fiction with an accent. With the sensational triumph of Adiga, who is brainy as well as funny, India has again regained its supremacy in the international lit-mart. And his next book, *Between the Assassinations*, which is actually his first book—a collection of stories which can also be called a biography of a place somewhere in the south—is out in November (see *excerpt*). Elsewhere in the novel, the narrator defines the white tiger as "the creature that comes along only once in a generation". That is the only autobiographical bit in this novel.

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